(Kim et al. 2015, p. 330), also provide an online space for individuals to directly convey their messages to other users. Kim et al. (2015) highlighted how 'microblogs' are used by the United States as 'tools to communicate with citizens, to learn about ideas, and to establish a network of people, in addition to serving as a new outlet for important announcements' (2015, p. 330). They further explored the use of Twitter by the Korean government and concluded 'that services for transparency/openness through social media can positively affect people's trust in the government directly and that services for engagement/participation and communication/relationship enhance the trust and perceived reliability of the government agency that provides the service, which indirectly enhances trust in the central government' (2015, p. 348). The use of Twitter by the president of the United States, Donald Trump, for communicating not only with the citizens of his country but also with world leaders demonstrates both the potential and the danger of such social networking websites, which are meant to allow uncensored freedom of expression (though these websites have the ability to censor their own users depending on the nature of the message).

In the case of Pakistan, Hussain (2014) has studied the use of social media by the chief secretary's office of Gilgit Baltistan to show the possibility of strengthening the state–citizen relationship through social media sites like Facebook. The chief secretary set up a Facebook page for the purpose of providing 'an additional channel of public communication, to enhance government outreach, to increase transparency and to counter corruption in order to improve governance in Gilgit-Baltistan' (Hussain 2014, p. 2). With the number of 'followers' increasing to '22,754 people', the chief secretary provided the citizens an opportunity to directly correspond with him and his office. The success of this initiative is evident in the way the chief secretary was able to address direct complaints of his constituents, 'improve citizens' participation in project planning', and 'tackle corruption' as citizens could share their complaints about local officers directly with the chief secretary (Hussain 2014).

Yusaf (2015) highlights the importance of 'new media technologies' during the lawyers' movement when 'anti-Musharraf activists used SMS networks to organize flash mobs; university students used a combination of blogs, e-mail lists, and SMS messages to organize protests; and protestors used cameras on their mobile phones to document and archive their action on Flickr and YouTube' (2015, p. 159). Members of the Pakistani diaspora were connected to the movement 'through Facebook'. The use of social media by political parties like the PTI is also highlighted by Yusaf. As she observes, Imran Khan's 'official Facebook page had attracted 487,000 "likes" and had 100,000 more followers than the PTI's